followed by action against G. Subramania Iyer, S. Krishnaswamy Sarma and Ethiraj Surendranath Arya. Following the arrest of the *de jure* editor of *India*, Subramania Bharati fled to Pondicherry to continue its publication.



The protest violence of 13 March marked the high point of the Swadeshi movement in south India. SSNCo lay at its foundation. In launching the company, VOC had challenged the British Empire.

The government was also under pressure from the European mercantile community in India. As the movement was hitting them where it hurt the most—their purse—European business interests expressed great dissatisfaction with the government's 'ineffective response'. A long-standing president of the Madras Chamber of Commerce (and director of Parry's), A.J. Yorke excoriated the 'safety-valve' principle regarding the freedom of expression as unsuitable for India. Had the many small garrisons dotting the presidency not been removed, he wrote in chilling words, 'Cocanada, Tuticorin and Tinnevelly would not have forgotten themselves'.[64]

While the colonial state blamed VOC's speeches and the propaganda for SSNCo for the violence, Indian nationalist opinion had no doubt that it was the result of the government's efforts to crush the shipping company. If *The Hindu*, from Madras said 'the Swadeshi company had nothing to do with the strike or riot',[65] Aurobindo wrote from Calcutta in the *Bande Mataram*: citing the daily *Madras Standard*, he traced its origins to 'the establishment of the Swadeshi Steam Navigation Company and the attempt to throw difficulties in the way of its success'. In Aurobindo's view,

> [t]he struggle generated an acute feeling on both sides and when commercial war extended itself and people took sides with Indian labour against British capital in the affairs of the Coral Mills, the patience of the English officials gave way and they rushed to the help of their mercantile caste-fellows, misusing the sacred seal of justice and the strong arm of power as instruments to maintain their trade supremacy.